PROPOSAL · 13 OCTOBER 2026 · SOHO SQUARE GARDENS, W1D 3QH

The Garden Below

Variant D · a perfume museum beneath Soho Square

Below the lawn there is a 300 m^2 machine hall: a 1928 DC converter substation that became a Blitz shelter, sealed since about 2015. This proposal turns it into a small, hosted perfume museum with a London flagship for Tiziana Terenzi. This page sets out one of four design directions, with its floor plan and long section.



SOHO SQUARE GARDENS · 1132

FLOOR

297 m²

3,200 sq ft, 2015 particulars

PLAN

30 × 10 m

estimate, east–west

DEPTH

3.5–4.5 m

below the lawn, estimate

BUILT

1928

substation, WWII shelter

STAIRS

2

west hatch + Grade II hut

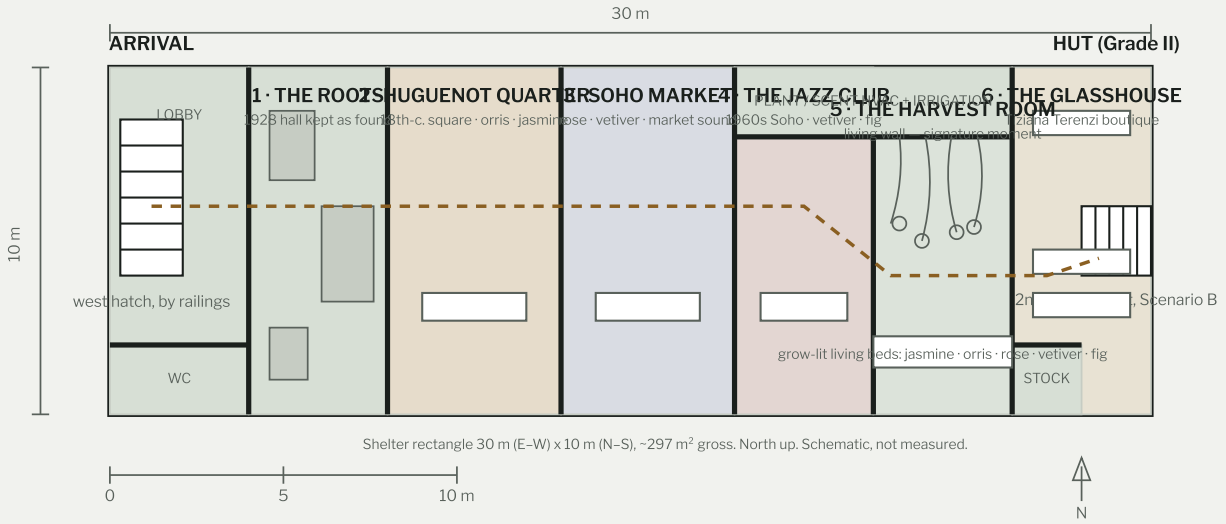
VISITORS

60–70

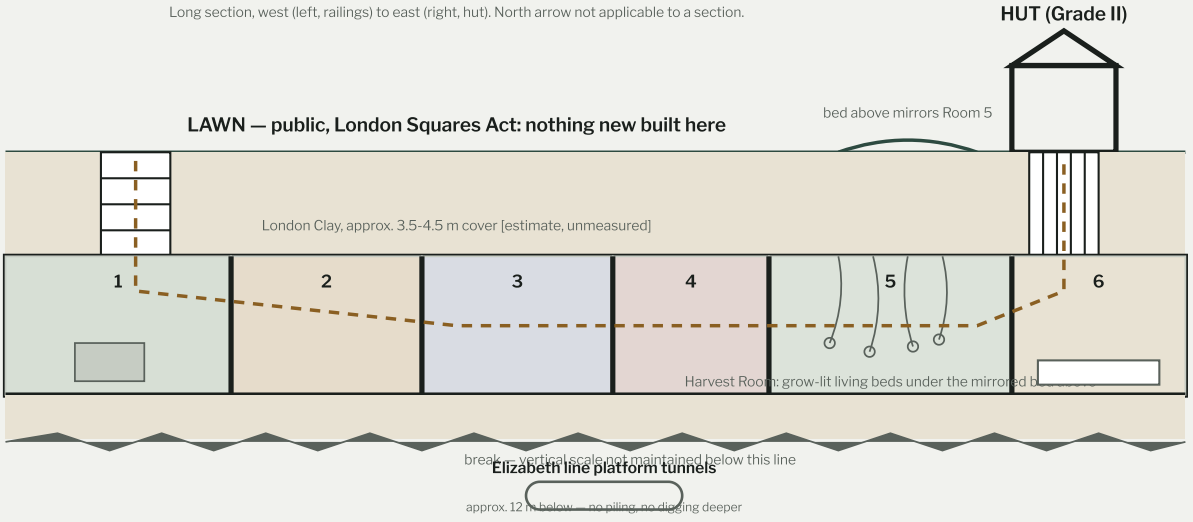
at once, both stairs rebuilt

D The Garden Below

Soho Square turned upside down: the lawn you just walked across is growing, lit and breathing, right over your head.



Floor plan, 1:200 at 20 px/m. 30 × 10 m hall, about 297 m². West stair = arrival, hut stair = second exit.



Long section, west to east. Depths are estimates until measured.

The idea

Soho Square's garden is public and untouchable (London Squares Act, 1931 Act) — so this variant doesn't compete with it, it mirrors it. Underground, directly beneath the beds and plane trees above, a botanical olfactory garden hangs from the ceiling: sculpted roots tracing the real planting above, grow-lit beds of living jasmine, orris, rose, vetiver and fig growing in genuine cultivation (not diffused

scent — actual plants under horticultural LED). The walk tells 300 years of what this one patch of London has smelled of: the 18th-century aristocratic square, the Huguenot silk-and-soap quarter, Soho's street markets, a 1960s jazz club, and finally the live "harvest" itself. Seasonal exhibitions are synced with what's actually flowering in the real garden overhead. It ends in Tiziana Terenzi's boutique, built as a steel-and-glass glasshouse. Joyful, green, family-friendly, and the strongest public-benefit story of any variant on the table: a museum that gives the council's garden back to it, underground.

The visit, room by room

A hosted walk for groups of up to 14, about 70 minutes, west to east along the shelter's full 30 m length (two protected escape stairs, Scenario B, so the 18 m single-direction limit doesn't bite).

1. **Arrival & The Roots** (8 min) — descend the west hatch into the lobby, under a canopy of cast "root" sculptures tracing the real plane trees and beds above (position data from a garden survey [estimate: exact root architecture is artistic licence, not a scan of actual roots]). The 1928 machine hall's hoist, plinths and cable cleats are kept as found underneath the canopy — the site's own history as the foundation the garden grows from. One diffused "wet soil and leaf" atmosphere.
2. **The Huguenot Quarter** (10 min) — 18th-century Soho: silk weavers, wig powder, tallow and the first physic-garden planting of the square. Smelling strips of orris root and jasmine (the weavers' perfumers' trade). Panelling references silk-loom timber.
3. **Soho Market** (10 min) — Berwick Street and the street markets: fish, cut flowers, veg, roasting coffee, tobacco. Rose and vetiver on blotters; a market-stall soundscape (barrow wheels, cries, bus brakes).
4. **The Jazz Club** (10 min) — 1950s–60s Soho nightlife: smoke, leather banquettes, spilled whisky. Vetiver and fig, low red light, a looping horn line. The smallest, densest room, deliberately claustrophobic before the next room opens up.
5. **The Harvest Room** (18 min, the signature stop) — the living wall: jasmine, orris, rose, vetiver and fig growing under broad-spectrum grow-lights set into the ceiling exactly where the beds sit above, roots visibly hanging through an open lattice ceiling. A seasonal "harvest" exhibition (what's actually blooming upstairs, this week) with a small working still. Visitors can touch, smell and occasionally take a cutting.
6. **The Glasshouse (Tiziana Terenzi boutique)** (15–20 min) — a steel-and-glass greenhouse structure built inside the hall. Testers and dummy flacons on display; stock in a fire-rated 30-minute store per HSG51. Exit back up the west stair, timed against the next group's descent.

The signature moment

Standing under the Harvest Room's open lattice ceiling, surrounded by real growing jasmine, rose, vetiver, orris and fig under a canopy of hanging cast roots, with a live camera feed showing the actual bed overhead at that exact moment — the thing people photograph and post is "the garden is growing *under* the garden."

Making it super cool

- **Living wall, not diffusion** — real cultivated plants under horticultural LED "false sun" panels is the one device no rival perfume museum has; everyone else diffuses or distills, nobody grows.
- **Root canopy installation** — cast resin/fibre roots in the lobby and Harvest Room, lit to pulse gently, mapped to a wind sensor on the real trees above [estimate: a nice-to-have gimmick, needs a live data feed from a rooftop or tree-mounted sensor].
- **Live garden camera** — a discreet rooftop feed of the actual bed above the Harvest Room, shown on a screen at the "harvest" moment, so the underground and overground gardens visibly sync.
- **Scent discipline** — at most one diffused atmosphere per room plus closed smelling domes and blotters for everything else (the Osmothèque method; the Paris natural-history museum trial found visitors can reliably place only ~7 scents per visit).
- **Soundscape layering** — bone-conduction headsets per room (market cries, jazz horns, birdsong) so rooms don't bleed into each other acoustically either.
- **Materials** — reclaimed Soho shopfront tile and timber in rooms 2–4, then glasshouse glass, painted steel and cork flooring from room 5 onward — a visible material shift from "street" to "garden."
- **Take-home ritual** — every visitor leaves with a tagged seed packet or rooted cutting from that week's harvest, dated to their visit.
- **"Adopt a plant" naming wall** — small brass tags in the Harvest Room sponsored by schools, families or the Soho Society; ties the museum into the square's own community rather than just monetising it.

Above ground

Arrival is the existing west hatch by the railings — nothing new on the lawn, no kiosk, no queue (1931 Act, London Squares Preservation Act). Guests check in by phone/QR at the gate; groups are staggered so nobody waits visibly on the grass. The hut (Grade II) is rebuilt as the second protected escape stair plus a platform lift shaft (Scenario B) — it stays an empty stair head, no retail or signage in it, consistent with its listing. A single discreet brass plaque by the hatch; no signage visible from the square's sightlines. The "live garden camera" used inside is the only piece of kit on the lawn itself, disguised as an ordinary bird-box or lamp fitting [estimate: needs WCC and the Garden Committee's sign-off either way].

Formats & money

All figures are estimates, ±30–50%, pending a measured survey — see the dossier.

TICKET	PRICE (INCL. VAT)	NOTES
Standard walk	£28 adult / £16 child	the six-room, 70-min hosted walk
Family ticket	£78 (2 adults + 2 children)	positions the museum as a family day out, not just a brand experience
Twilight Garden (evening, grow-lights on full, no alcohol)	£42	two evening slots a day
Harvest Workshop (seed-planting / cutting, kids)	£18 per child, 45 min	school holidays and weekends
Private hire / launch	£3,000–£4,500 evening buy-out	Terenzi launches, corporate, garden-charity events

- **Capacity:** groups of 14 every 30 min, two protected escape routes (Scenario B) lifting the single-stair 60-person cap; design occupancy ~55–70 at once on a normal day, up to ~150 for an evening event per the dossier's two-stair reading.
- **Terenzi boutique role:** the Glasshouse is Terenzi-operated (keeps the 75–85% retail margin with them, not an operating company); estimated 25–30% conversion at the exit of a room that has just shown visitors real rose, orris, vetiver and fig growing, against a £140–£180 average spend.
- **Non-obvious revenue line:** a mail-order/online "Grow Your Own Soho Garden" kit (orris, jasmine or fig cutting + a Terenzi-branded scent-matched candle), sold year-round off the museum's own propagation, not just at the till — turns the living wall into a standing product line rather than a one-off visit upsell.
- **Rough annual revenue [estimate]:** mid case ≈ £1.7m–£2.1m net (tickets + workshops + private hire + boutique + grow-kits), broadly in line with the dossier's §5b mid case, with family/workshop tickets adding volume the dossier's adult-only model didn't price.

Fit with the constraints

- **Fire:** depends on the hut being successfully rebuilt as a genuine second protected stair (Scenario B) — if WCC/Historic England refuse that, the plan compresses to rooms 1–3 only within the 18 m single-route limit, and the Harvest Room's signature moment moves to the middle of the walk instead of the end. Honest risk, not a given.
- **Heritage:** machine pits, plinths and the hoist runway are kept as found and worked into Room 1 rather than removed; the hut's listed fabric is touched only for the stair/lift it already needs under Scenario B.
- **HVAC:** this variant adds a genuinely new M&E load the dossier didn't price — a living-plant room needs its own irrigation, drainage, humidity and grow-light heat load on top of the scent-room extract already required for Rooms 2–4. Budget an extra horticultural plant allowance beyond the dossier's §5a HVAC line [estimate, not costed here].
- **Accessibility:** step-free depends on the same platform lift at the west hatch the base dossier already flags (£60k–£150k); the Harvest Room's lattice ceiling and uneven planting beds need a firm, level visitor path cut through them for wheelchair and pushchair access — doable, but a specific design constraint this variant adds.

Risks

- **Living plants are a live system, not a fixed exhibit** — a failed crop, pest outbreak or lighting fault before a scheduled "harvest" event is a real operational risk with no easy understudy; needs a horticulturist on staff, not just hosts.
- **Humidity conflict**: fragrance wants 40–60% RH and the plants want comparable or higher humidity near the grow-beds, but the shelter is already damp-prone and historically bricked-up — the two systems can probably be zoned apart, but that's an added engineering ask on top of the dossier's §4a scent-room design, not proven here.
- **Second-escape dependency**: the whole six-room, 30 m-long, family-pitched version of this variant needs the hut rebuilt as a working protected stair (Scenario B); if that fails, both the room count and the family-ticket economics shrink together.

Prepared by Mia for Alessandro Ticchi, 13/10/2026. Dimensions are estimates from photographs and 2015 press reports. Nothing here has been measured. Site photos: 28DaysLater, Forever Changes, Subterranea Britannica, Evening Standard (2015). Revenue figures are rough estimates for discussion.